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HAPPINESS, FAITH AND DOUBT

POTENTIAL HAS to be harnessed. Unfortunately, mine wasn't.

I don't think I was treated and groomed the way I should have been. Coaches and captains didn't exploit my talent to the fullest. I was misused. Not deployed properly, nor unleashed. There is a whole roster of coaches, especially Pakistani coaches, who wanted me to play the way they had played the game. They wanted to recreate me as a reflection of their own image. This created in me the biggest defect a cricketer can have: doubt.

I became double-minded. Confused, really. There was an entire phase in my career where I would take to the pitch but couldn't deliver the way I should have. I wasn't myself. I feared staying on the pitch because I felt I wasn't really meant to be there. I feared heading back to the dressing room because of my fear of getting out. If I bungled the innings, got out, or didn't bat like I was supposed to, or if I let the coach down, it would scare the hell out of me and haunt my game. This happened with a number of coaches, over the years. The vicious circle of doubt kept getting bigger.

Then came a tipping point: Bob Woolmer, the only coach who let me play like I wanted to play. Just like the way I was born to play. He told me to just be myself. I stopped worrying how much cricket there was left in me and went back to playing the way I always wanted to.

And then there was the bowling, which, I must repeat, is what I was really born to do, and given the national cap for. I had a healthy rivalry with Saqlain Mushtaq, the wily off-spinner. He was a death overs specialist. He would wrap up the tail like it was an Eid gift. He loved doing it.

I remember, once Saqlain and I got into a debate. I goaded him into an argument which stood statistically, telling him he could only deal with tail-enders, while most of my wickets were of top- and middle-order batsmen. He bet wrongly. We went to the team stats guru and guess what – about 60 per cent of Saqlain's wickets were indeed tail-enders. Meanwhile, about 70 per cent of my wickets were top- and middle-order batsmen.

Unfortunately, I wasn't developed as a bowler, especially in the early years. I was never given